# FHS INTERNAL EXAM REPORT

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# Politics FHS 2023 - exam performance statistics by paper and school

| | School | Take up | Mean | St. Dev | Max | Min | >=70% | >=60 | >=50 | >=40 | Q1 | Median | Q3 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Total** | **Combined** | 1008 | 65.71 | 6.48 | 85 | 17 | 25.30% | 62.80% | 10.22% | 1.09% | 63 | 66 | 70 |
| | **DPPE** | 796 | 65.80 | 6.05 | 85 | 17 | 24.75% | 62.81% | 10.43% | 1.38% | 63 | 66 | 70 |
| | **DMHP** | 212 | 65.88 | 5.26 | 80 | 37 | 27.36% | 62.74% | 9.43% | 0.00% | 63 | 66 | 70 |
| **Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice** | **Combined** | 44 | 63.91 | 8.22 | 74 | 17 | 13.64% | 75.00% | 9.09% | 0.00% | 61.8 | 64.5 | 68 |
| | **DPPE** | 39 | 64.13 | 8.66 | 74 | 17 | 15.38% | 74.36% | 7.69% | 0.00% | 62 | 65 | 68 |
| | **DMHP** | 5 | 62.20 | 2.48 | 66 | 59 | 0.00% | 80.00% | 20.00% | 0.00% | 60 | 63 | 63 |
| **British Politics and Government since 1900** | **Combined** | 94 | 64.05 | 7.02 | 80 | 48 | 21.28% | 53.19% | 18.09% | 6.38% | 60 | 64 | 68 |
| | **DPPE** | 70 | 63.80 | 7.74 | 80 | 48 | 21.43% | 47.14% | 21.43% | 8.57% | 59 | 64 | 69 |
| | **DMHP** | 24 | 64.79 | 4.28 | 74 | 56 | 20.83% | 70.83% | 8.33% | 0.00% | 62 | 64 | 66.3 |
| **Comparative Demographic Systems** | **Combined** | 3 | 65.67 | 1.70 | 68 | 64 | 0.00% | 100.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64.5 | 65 | 66.5 |
| | **DPPE** | 3 | 65.67 | 1.70 | 68 | 64 | 0.00% | 100.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64.5 | 65 | 66.5 |
| | **DMHP** | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - |
| **Comparative Government** | **Combined** | 69 | 66.07 | 6.96 | 85 | 45 | 31.88% | 47.83% | 17.39% | 2.90% | 62 | 67 | 71 |
| | **DPPE** | 58 | 66.16 | 7.27 | 85 | 45 | 34.48% | 44.83% | 17.24% | 3.45% | 62 | 67 | 71 |
| | **DMHP** | 11 | 65.64 | 5.00 | 74 | 58 | 18.18% | 63.64% | 18.18% | 0.00% | 62 | 66 | 68.5 |
| **Comparative Political Economy** | **Combined** | 28 | 64.93 | 5.55 | 72 | 51 | 25.00% | 53.57% | 21.43% | 0.00% | 62 | 65.5 | 69.3 |
| | **DPPE** | 24 | 64.96 | 5.63 | 72 | 51 | 25.00% | 54.17% | 20.83% | 0.00% | 62 | 66 | 69.3 |
| | **DMHP** | 4 | 64.75 | 5.02 | 71 | 57 | 25.00% | 50.00% | 25.00% | 0.00% | 63 | 65.5 | 67.3 |
| **Government and Politics of the United States** | **Combined** | 22 | 65.73 | 5.00 | 75 | 57 | 27.27% | 63.64% | 9.09% | 0.00% | 62.3 | 64.5 | 69.8 |
| | **DPPE** | 16 | 65.88 | 5.05 | 75 | 57 | 31.25% | 62.50% | 6.25% | 0.00% | 62.8 | 63.5 | 70 |
| | **DMHP** | 6 | 65.33 | 4.85 | 73 | 59 | 16.67% | 66.67% | 16.67% | 0.00% | 61.3 | 65.5 | 68.3 |
| **International Relations** | **Combined** | 157 | 65.49 | 5.17 | 76 | 37 | 21.02% | 65.61% | 12.10% | 0.64% | 63 | 66 | 69 |
| | **DPPE** | 117 | 65.44 | 4.77 | 76 | 46 | 18.80% | 66.67% | 13.68% | 0.85% | 63 | 66 | 68 |
| | **DMHP** | 40 | 65.65 | 6.20 | 74 | 37 | 27.50% | 62.50% | 7.50% | 0.00% | 63 | 67 | 70 |
| **International Relations in the Era of the Cold War** | **Combined** | 23 | 65.43 | 6.43 | 74 | 41 | 21.74% | 69.57% | 4.35% | 4.35% | 64 | 66 | 69 |
| | **DPPE** | 16 | 65.06 | 7.27 | 74 | 41 | 18.75% | 68.75% | 6.25% | 6.25% | 64 | 66 | 69 |
| | **DMHP** | 7 | 66.29 | 3.73 | 71 | 60 | 28.57% | 71.43% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64 | 67 | 69 |
| **International Relations in the Era of Two World Wars** | **Combined** | 11 | 67.00 | 6.89 | 80 | 55 | 45.45% | 36.36% | 18.18% | 0.00% | 64 | 69 | 70 |
| | **DPPE** | 7 | 64.43 | 5.92 | 70 | 55 | 28.57% | 42.86% | 28.57% | 0.00% | 60.5 | 66 | 69.5 |
| | **DMHP** | 4 | 71.50 | 6.10 | 80 | 63 | 75.00% | 25.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 68.3 | 71.5 | 74.8 |
| **Marx and Marxism** | **Combined** | 19 | 66.89 | 4.24 | 75 | 57 | 26.32% | 68.42% | 5.26% | 0.00% | 65 | 68 | 69.5 |
| | **DPPE** | 16 | 67.44 | 4.32 | 75 | 57 | 31.25% | 62.50% | 6.25% | 0.00% | 65 | 69 | 70 |
| | **DMHP** | 3 | 64.00 | 2.16 | 66 | 61 | 0.00% | 100.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 63 | 65 | 65.5 |
| **Modern British Government and Politics** | **Combined** | 28 | 65.86 | 3.46 | 73 | 58 | 21.43% | 75.00% | 3.57% | 0.00% | 63 | 65 | 69 |
| | **DPPE** | 25 | 65.88 | 3.48 | 73 | 58 | 20.00% | 76.00% | 4.00% | 0.00% | 63 | 65 | 69 |
| | **DMHP** | 3 | 65.67 | 3.30 | 70 | 62 | 33.33% | 66.67% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 63.5 | 65 | 67.5 |

| | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Political Sociology** | **Combined** | 99 | 65.62 | 5.65 | 76 | 27 | 19.19% | 71.72% | 7.07% | 0.00% | 63.3 | 66 | 69 |
| | **DPPE** | 78 | 65.42 | 5.83 | 76 | 27 | 15.38% | 75.64% | 6.41% | 0.00% | 64 | 66 | 68 |
| | **DMHP** | 21 | 66.38 | 4.84 | 74 | 57 | 33.33% | 57.14% | 9.52% | 0.00% | 63 | 66 | 70 |
| **Political Thought: Bentham to Weber** | **Combined** | 10 | 66.20 | 9.80 | 75 | 39 | 50.00% | 40.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64.3 | 69 | 72 |
| | **DPPE** | 8 | 65.25 | 10.45 | 73 | 39 | 50.00% | 37.50% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64 | 69 | 72 |
| | **DMHP** | 2 | 70.00 | 5.00 | 75 | 65 | 50.00% | 50.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 67.5 | 70 | 72.5 |
| **Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau** | **Combined** | 17 | 68.41 | 5.26 | 78 | 59 | 35.29% | 58.82% | 5.88% | 0.00% | 65 | 69 | 70 |
| | **DPPE** | 14 | 67.64 | 4.99 | 78 | 59 | 28.57% | 64.29% | 7.14% | 0.00% | 64.5 | 68.5 | 69.8 |
| | **DMHP** | 3 | 72.00 | 4.97 | 76 | 65 | 66.67% | 33.33% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 70 | 75 | 75.5 |
| **Politics in China** | **Combined** | 29 | 63.86 | 5.78 | 75 | 54 | 24.14% | 55.17% | 20.69% | 0.00% | 60 | 64 | 67 |
| | **DPPE** | 24 | 64.29 | 5.51 | 75 | 54 | 25.00% | 62.50% | 12.50% | 0.00% | 60 | 64 | 67.8 |
| | **DMHP** | 5 | 61.80 | 6.52 | 72 | 56 | 20.00% | 20.00% | 60.00% | 0.00% | 56 | 58 | 67 |
| **Politics in Europe** | **Combined** | 5 | 67.60 | 2.87 | 73 | 65 | 20.00% | 80.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 66 | 66 | 68 |
| | **DPPE** | 5 | 67.60 | 2.87 | 73 | 65 | 20.00% | 80.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 66 | 66 | 68 |
| | **DMHP** | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - |
| **Politics in Latin America** | **Combined** | 15 | 65.53 | 7.08 | 75 | 45 | 40.00% | 53.33% | 0.00% | 6.67% | 62.5 | 66 | 70 |
| | **DPPE** | 11 | 65.55 | 7.57 | 75 | 45 | 45.45% | 45.45% | 0.00% | 9.09% | 64 | 67 | 70 |
| | **DMHP** | 4 | 65.50 | 5.50 | 75 | 62 | 25.00% | 75.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 62 | 62.5 | 66 |
| **Politics in Russia and the Former Soviet Union** | **Combined** | 16 | 65.25 | 4.79 | 76 | 60 | 25.00% | 75.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 62 | 63 | 67.8 |
| | **DPPE** | 11 | 65.09 | 4.68 | 76 | 60 | 18.18% | 81.82% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 62 | 63 | 67 |
| | **DMHP** | 5 | 65.60 | 5.00 | 73 | 60 | 40.00% | 60.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 62 | 63 | 70 |
| **Politics in South Asia** | **Combined** | 5 | 69.20 | 3.82 | 75 | 65 | 60.00% | 40.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 65 | 70 | 71 |
| | **DPPE** | 3 | 68.33 | 4.71 | 75 | 65 | 33.33% | 66.67% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 65 | 65 | 70 |
| | **DMHP** | 2 | 70.50 | 0.50 | 71 | 70 | 100.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 70.3 | 70.5 | 70.8 |
| **Politics in Sub-Saharan Africa** | **Combined** | 17 | 66.35 | 5.74 | 78 | 54 | 29.41% | 64.71% | 5.88% | 0.00% | 63 | 66 | 71 |
| | **DPPE** | 10 | 65.70 | 6.60 | 78 | 54 | 30.00% | 60.00% | 10.00% | 0.00% | 61 | 66 | 69.8 |
| | **DMHP** | 7 | 67.29 | 4.03 | 75 | 63 | 28.57% | 71.43% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64.5 | 65 | 69.5 |
| **Politics in the Middle East** | **Combined** | 29 | 67.07 | 4.87 | 78 | 59 | 27.59% | 68.97% | 3.45% | 0.00% | 63 | 66 | 71 |
| | **DPPE** | 21 | 66.90 | 4.50 | 76 | 61 | 28.57% | 71.43% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 63 | 65 | 71 |
| | **DMHP** | 8 | 67.50 | 5.70 | 78 | 59 | 25.00% | 62.50% | 12.50% | 0.00% | 63 | 67.5 | 70 |
| **Social Policy** | **Combined** | 24 | 65.96 | 5.03 | 75 | 55 | 25.00% | 62.50% | 12.50% | 0.00% | 63 | 66 | 68.5 |
| | **DPPE** | 21 | 66.05 | 4.64 | 75 | 55 | 23.81% | 66.67% | 9.52% | 0.00% | 63 | 66 | 68 |
| | **DMHP** | 3 | 65.33 | 7.13 | 75 | 58 | 33.33% | 33.33% | 33.33% | 0.00% | 60.5 | 63 | 69 |
| **Sociological Theory** | **Combined** | 8 | 66.25 | 4.02 | 72 | 60 | 12.50% | 87.50% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64.5 | 67 | 69 |
| | **DPPE** | 8 | 66.25 | 4.02 | 72 | 60 | 12.50% | 87.50% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64.5 | 67 | 69 |
| | **DMHP** | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - | - |
| **Special Subject in Politics: Feminist Theory** | **Combined** | 25 | 67.52 | 4.08 | 75 | 59 | 28.00% | 68.00% | 4.00% | 0.00% | 65 | 68 | 70 |
| | **DPPE** | 22 | 67.50 | 4.18 | 75 | 59 | 27.27% | 68.18% | 4.55% | 0.00% | 65 | 68 | 69.8 |
| | **DMHP** | 3 | 67.67 | 3.30 | 72 | 64 | 33.33% | 66.67% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 65.5 | 67 | 69.5 |

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|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Special Subject in Politics: International Security and Conflict** | **Combined** | 48 | 66.94 | 3.06 | 72 | 60 | 25.00% | 75.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 65 | 67 | 69.3 |
| | **DPPE** | 37 | 66.84 | 2.75 | 71 | 60 | 18.92% | 81.08% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 65 | 67 | 69 |
| | **DMHP** | 11 | 67.27 | 3.93 | 72 | 60 | 45.45% | 54.55% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 64.5 | 67 | 70.5 |
| **The Politics of the European Union** | **Combined** | 8 | 64.75 | 5.85 | 73 | 54 | 25.00% | 62.50% | 12.50% | 0.00% | 62.3 | 64 | 69 |
| | **DPPE** | 7 | 65.00 | 6.21 | 73 | 54 | 28.57% | 57.14% | 14.29% | 0.00% | 62 | 64 | 70 |
| | **DMHP** | 1 | 63.00 | 0.00 | 63 | 63 | 0.00% | 100.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 63 | 63 | 63 |
| **Theory of Politics** | **Combined** | 130 | 66.32 | 5.38 | 81 | 53 | 29.23% | 58.46% | 12.31% | 0.00% | 63 | 66 | 70 |
| | **DPPE** | 107 | 66.76 | 5.57 | 81 | 53 | 32.71% | 55.14% | 12.15% | 0.00% | 63 | 67 | 70 |
| | **DMHP** | 23 | 64.30 | 3.82 | 72 | 58 | 13.04% | 73.91% | 13.04% | 0.00% | 62 | 64 | 65.5 |
| **Thesis in Politics** | **Combined** | 21 | 70.67 | 6.43 | 85 | 60 | 47.62% | 52.38% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 66 | 69 | 75 |
| | **DPPE** | 16 | 70.81 | 6.88 | 85 | 60 | 50.00% | 50.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 65.8 | 70 | 75.3 |
| | **DMHP** | 5 | 70.20 | 4.71 | 78 | 65 | 40.00% | 60.00% | 0.00% | 0.00% | 67 | 68 | 73 |

# Report on A15005W1 Theory of Politics

**1. ‘ Ideal theory necessarily overlooks matters of rectification and is therefore of little use for addressing injustice.’ Discuss with reference EITHER to race OR to global justice.**

Relatively few answers. Those that did answer often focused on Rawls, although some more sophisticated responses offered a more expansive view of how to understand ‘ideal theory’. Answers tended to divide between weak and strong. Those on the weaker side generally failed to grapple with both components of the question and were slanted towards either an analysis of ideal theory, or substantive questions of race/global justice, rather than giving due attention to both. The best answers not only avoided this pitfall but also explored how far addressing injustice requires rectification.

**2. Can power operate without a specific agent wielding it?**

A reasonably popular question that all too often invited very general discussion of how to conceptualise power. Stronger answers were able to appeal to a breadth of relevant literature and were also distinguished by their close attention to the relation between power and agency.

**3. ‘I am free to the extent that I do not depend on another’s will.’ Do you agree?**

A popular question that was for the most part answered reasonably well, although some weaker answers involved only general reflections on the nature of freedom without tethering this to the particular question. Candidates often took the question as an invitation to discuss freedom as non-domination, and the best such answers evidenced strong understanding of that position, aligned with critical discussion of what it might mean to depend on the will of another.

**4. Should we hold people responsible for disadvantages resulting from their beliefs or identities?**

A reasonable number of candidates answered this question but very few produced particularly strong responses. Many interpreted this question through the lens of luck egalitarianism. Those answers tended to offer some sensible analysis of the connection between responsibility and disadvantage in relation to choice, but struggled to say much of substance in respect of beliefs and identities specifically. A small minority of (more successful) answers not only distinguished between beliefs and identity, but also reflected on various reasons why liability may or may not be appropriately based on such factors.

**5. 'Left-libertarians need to pick a side – liberty or equality.' Discuss.**

A challenging question that not only required good understanding of a specific libertarian position but also required candidates to do some interpretive work in establishing what the question was driving at. This may have been the reason that the question attracted few takers, but those candidates who took on the challenge tended to offer strong responses. The best among them evidenced good understanding of left-libertarian positions and were able to productively explore potential tensions between liberty and equality therein.

**6. Is Liberal Socialism a coherent position?**

Very few answers, most of which were disappointingly poor. Answers tended to gesture towards coherence rather than exploring it in detail and generally offered relatively superficial characterisations of Liberalism and Socialism.

**7. 'Egalitarians should care more about the relationships within which goods are distributed than about the distributions themselves.' Discuss.**

A popular question. Weaker answers took the question as an invitation to rehearse a general discussion of the relational vs distributive egalitarian debate, a surprising number of which seemed to assume that distributive egalitarianism should take a luck egalitarian form. Still, most answers evidenced a reasonably good understanding of some of the main moves in that debate. Candidates often failed to pay attention to the specifically comparative character of the question ('care more'), and even fewer reflected in any detail specifically on relationships 'within which goods are distributed' (rather than relationships as such). The best answers explored a range of relational egalitarian reasons for being concerned with distributions.

**8. Should feminists assume that women as a group share some feature, experience, or common condition?**

Answers to this question ranged widely in quality. Weaker answers tended to rely on simply asserting the importance, or otherwise, of commonality across women, whereas stronger answers tended to present more well-supported claims, with appreciation of competing views. Some of the more interesting responses disaggregated 'feature, experience, or common condition' and reflected on the significance of each. Only small minority candidates paid attention to the term 'assume' in the question, but those that did tended to explore this element fruitfully.

**9. "'Civility" as a requirement for justified disobedience does not apply to oppressed members of society.' Discuss.**

A question that attracted few answers but largely divided responses into weak and strong. Some candidates struggled with the complexity of the question – it required analysis of 'civility', discussion of the standards for justified disobedience and reflection on the significance of being an 'oppressed member of society'. As a result, weaker answers often offered a one dimensional focus on only a part of the question. There were a couple of excellent answers that showed strong understanding of relevant literature on civil disobedience and included nuanced analysis of the relevance of oppression.

**10. Is distributive justice primarily a matter of reciprocity between equals?**

A surprisingly unpopular question that was answered relatively poorly for the most part. Some candidates discussed Rawls but only in very general terms. Others took the question to allude to Dworkin's discussion of the requirement to treat citizens with equal concern and respect, but neglected to focus on reciprocity. With a few exceptions, candidates failed to address the worry that reciprocity-based conceptions of justice overlook non-contributors. The candidates that did focus on this issue generally offered sophisticated, relevant analysis.

**11. 'If we could truly trust the experts, then democracy would be redundant.' Discuss.**

Moderately popular question with a spread of quality of answers. Some weak answers offered only a superficial discussion of the competing merits of democracy as against other forms of government. Surprisingly few candidates paid careful attention to the logical structure of the question and focused attention on questioning trust in expertise, rather than analysing the hypothetical scenario in which experts can be trusted. Better answers explored different senses in which experts might be trusted and engaged reasons to value democracy beyond any capacity to deliver good outcomes.

**12. 'The "reasonable" citizen is simply the liberal citizen.' If so, are Political Liberal claims to neutrality a sham?**

Another challenging question that attracted few answers but among them some impressive ones. Those answers evidenced understanding of a broad range of relevant material alongside careful analysis of different ways in which Political Liberals have characterised 'reasonable'.

# Report on A12720W1 British Politics and Government since 1900

94 candidates; 70 in PPE; 24 in History and Politics

The choice of questions by PPE and HP candidates was broadly similar.

**Question One: Has the importance of New Liberalism to the Liberal Governments of 1906-1915 been exaggerated? [34 answers]**

Good answers demonstrated clear knowledge of New Liberalism and what it was, and also the legislation of the government. Very good answers (of which there were several) discussed how a set of ideas was fruitful of legislation. They also explained why the study of New Liberalism itself was a matter of controversy. A few struggled a little because they plainly knew about the government, or New Liberalism, but not both.

Weak scripts showed scraps of information, grasped from basic reading. Claims included election victories in years in which their victors were so ill that the king wanted a second election, New Liberalism did not exist because Liberals had rejected it, and so on.

Most scripts were articulate and persuasive whether they agreed or took issue with the question.

**Question Two: Why did women suffragists find themselves unable to agree on questions of tactics? [23 answers]**

There was a wide variety of approaches in answering the question, which included a fairly simple division into suffragists and suffragettes and their aims, to a much more complex analysis placing "votes for women" amidst other big campaigns of 19004914. A few answers claimed the movement was not divided, as conventionally claimed, especially, of course at the end of the nineteenth century and again from 1914.

Some essays contained very interesting discussions. The influence of class was one; were activists more middle- or working-class and who did they want to have a vote. Local circumstances included the attitude of newspaper editors, the existence of funds, and the interpretation of supposed "violence". A few discussed the dubious proposition that "all publicity is good publicity".

The comments about political parties were rather sweeping. Just because Asquith opposed votes for women, it did not mean that his whole party believed the same. Nor did the support of the parliamentary Labour Party mean that the party in the country (especially trade unions) suddenly did the same. By 1918, of course, the political landscape had changed.

**Question Three: Had the Liberals successfully contained the Labour Party by 1914? [23 Answers]**

This question produced sophisticated and thoughtful answers. It allowed candidates to demonstrate knowledge the issues and how they were altering the dynamics of the political system. Good candidates (of whom there were plenty) mostly concluded that the answer was no, qualified by the assertion that Labour was not yet (1914) a big party, nor was it about to become one and neither was the franchise factor by itself about to make it one. Instead the growth trade unions in certain parts of Britain and stresses with-ifkthe Liberals over taxation and state intervention would weaken the party. Government foreign policy and imperialism were also held to be offensive to some Liberals and Labour alike. Some argued, to the contrary, that Labours growth had stalled and that the Liberals maintained their support from much of working-class

industrial Britain, and what they had lost had anyway gone to the Conservatives. Labour also had little to say other than the politics which the Liberals were actually pursuing.

Other themes were both raised, and their importance disputed (class consciousness, for example), in an impressive set of answers. Two ended by speculating that Labours growth might mean a long period of Conservative Government.

**Question Four: In what senses was the Labour Party ever a socialist party in the twentieth century? [34 answers]**

A question which allowed candidates to choose their own territory, whether economic or sociological or more mechanical. Clear answers from fluent scripts also usually demonstrated knowledge of whether socialist ideas were more appropriate to studies of opposition (many suggested 'yes') or to government (many suggested 'no'). A few adventurous candidates took periods of ideas and contrasted them with supposed periods of muddle (inter-war years and unemployment; and the 1980s featured often here). The best essays reached a very thoughtful and fluent standard.

Other answers were weak and the very weakest startling. Some candidates used the question when they had no others left to choose. They produced simple answers on the Blair government, stopping now and again to say that there was no sign of socialism. And there were vague chronological essays rambling through parts of the twentieth century with reference to Labour. Elections were often wrongly dated and leaders came in the wrong order. Definitions of `Socialism' were sometimes plainly not applicable to the Labour party.

Unsurprisingly, there was a wide range of marks on the paper, but several were first class.

**Question Five: Given its electoral success after 1918, why was the Conservative Party so reluctant to support franchise and electoral reform before 1918? [6 answers]**

Only a small number of answers, which tended to look at only part of the question. Franchise reform was often treated fleetingly, often only to claim that Conservatives were wrong before 1918 (even through some Conservatives supported reform before 1914). Essays which ignored the war completely put themselves in a difficult position as it becomes more difficult to explain the importance of 1918. In particular weaker essays began on an explanation of the decline of the Liberals. Other answers, which contained plenty of knowledge about the Conservatives before 1918, were far more compelling.

**Question Six: Are the failures of the British communist and fascist parties best explained in terms of British exceptionalism?**

No answers. This was a pity as it was clear from other answers which some candidate wrote that they had a good deal of knowledge about communists and fascists — and had probably decided not to revise the topic.

**Question Seven: Was the 1945 election a khaki election? [30 answers]**

A substantial number of candidates had prepared quite detailed information on 1945-51. Essays therefore, unsurprisingly, ranged from the excellent to the more recital of events (a few barely relevant). The question was another which gave the opportunity for a variety of interpretations, beginning with `khaki'. A few interesting answers compared 1945 with 1918 (and a very few with 1900 as well) to test what the word might mean. More common was to consider the election in the light of later

developments, and less common to ignore 'khaki' altogether and reproduce their tutorial essays.

Finally, a fascinating case involved assessing Britain's international position and arguing that a combination of imperial commitments and the rapid emergence of the Cold War meant the combination of National Service and the maintenance of a big deference budget. Therefore, the election was a khaki election, whatever Labour intended. Only a couple of answers developed this line, but it was clever and original. Essays on this question were usually good, showing plenty of knowledge of domestic developments, stressing the Beveridge Report and nationalisation, and arguing that they showed the real nature of constitutional socialism. They concluded by answering ` no' to the title question.

**Question Eight: Did the Conservative Party have to reinvent itself in order to win back power in the 1950s? [23 answers]**

A frequent word used in the interpretation of developments in the Conservative party is 'pragmatist re, a word much favoured here. Only a couple of essays argued broadly 'yes', stating that the party which returned to office in 1951 was so difference from the party of 1939, that 'reinvent' was justifiable. In support they used not only policy changes but writings of men like Butler and Macmillan.

Most essays took the contrary views. The legislation of the 1950s was a natural progression accepting both the changed demands of the electorate and Labour's legislation. Two candidates made an interesting claim that Conservative change after the Second World War was less than changes they absorbed after 1914-1918.

All answers to this question were competent, if usually a little uninspired.

**Question Nine: Why did British governments in the 1960s and 1970s struggle to modernise the economy? [10 answers]**

A small number of answers constructed their answers around failings in the economy and then why governments could not overcome them. More began with governments and the constraints under which they operated. One said, more simply, that governments had no place in the economy and then wandered into a free-market panegyric.

Candidates were rather too apt to pursue a chronological line which involved small election majorities, inefficient incomes policies and disruptive trade unions. Few candidates mentioned important papers ('In Place of Strife') or acts (Industrial Relations Act 1971), and inflation seemed to have occurred for no obvious reason. Only the best addressed failures to invest, problems of a frequently ailing public sector and how unemployment caused defensive industrial action. There were two or three excellent answers, but some others lacked analysis.

**Question Ten: What, besides free market economics, was there to Thatcherism? [63 answers]**

By far the most-answered question, with an eclectic range of approaches and arguments displayed, often fluently and effectively.

Some candidates were uncomfortable to be steered away from economics (a few were plainly happy). A few managed a skilful division into finance and economics, showing how the financial sector remained loyal to the government, while much of commercial and manufacturing had become disillusioned by the end of the 1980s. Another more common line was to dispute whether Conservatives from 1975 developed a clear programme. Although this is a familiar debate, candidates joined the fray energetically. Most thought

there was a programme, based around anti-trade unionism, free markets and property ownership. But if they succeeded, they then failed on further policy (Europe, Poll Tax) and Major's government achieved little. Many candidates considered that "Thatcherism" needed to be judged up to 1997 — or even beyond.

Finally, a few enjoyed making (gently malicious) remarks about the state of suspicion which existed between Conservatives and the senior civil service, the BBC and most of all the Church of England which, as Conservatives they nonetheless had to respect.

**Question Eleven: Why were so many Conservatives keen to join the EEC in 1973 yet keen to leave the EU in 2016? [5 answers]**

Essays were usually good on 2016, weak on 1973. Developments in the EU were said to be incompatible with what Conservatives wanted or expected, but what they did want was opaque in these answers. Two essays knew very little, stating that Mrs. Thatcher was always anti-European, guessing wrongly the date of the Maastricht Treaty and claiming that 2016 was the first European referendum. The other three essays were, unsurprisingly, better.

**Question Twelve: Why was there a coalition government from 2010 to 2015, but not on other occasions when there was a hung Parliament? [8 answers]**

Some answers knew a great deal about previous hung Parliaments and reasons why parties had sometimes co-operated without coalition. The electoral outcome in 2010 was analysed, frequently with comments about Conservative determination to regain office — and that this accounted for the over-representation which the Liberal Democrats were allowed.

Candidates examined whether (in their view) the coalition had worked efficiently (yes), whether it was necessary in the circumstances of 2010 (probably yes), was it an experiment to be repeated? (no). Much was said about why the coalition lasted a full five years and pointing out that it was more stable than some single-party governments (John Major from 1992 — 1997 was often referred to). A few essays were excellent, elegant arguments.

**General Comments:**

This year answers were spread more than previous years. Candidates' choices helped to account for the wider spread of marks. Very good candidates put more of their analytical capacity on display, accounting for the relatively high proportion of first-class marks. Weak candidates fell back on dimly remembered tutorials, accounting for many of the lowest marks.

Of course, a familiar comment from examiners is that attendance at lecturers would have helped students, but this is particularly true for those who only revise five topics. One would be likely not to appear on the paper, one to appear in a form for which the student had not revised, leaving only three which had been revised and no choice.

There is then a tendency to write essays which are chronological streams of facts. Lectures, and a little wider reading, would have helped these students substantially.

But the great majority of-students were much better and the best 10% or so really excellent. Many students were able to advertise debates amongst scholars and have views of their own, especially on New Liberalism (theory) and government (practice), Labour and Socialism, Thatcherism and free-market economics. They had read widely, thought carefully, and demonstrated the intellectual vibrancy of the paper.

# Report on A12721W1 Modern British Politics and Government

1. Has the British constitution been adversely affected by disputes over Brexit since 2016?

11 Answers

Strong Answers focused on how the discourse surrounding Brexit has significantly impacted the British constitution, exposing and testing the elasticity of its uncodified nature. Pivotal court judgments like Miller I and Miller II were scrutinized, as well as constitutional conventions such as those surrounding the Royal Prerogative, as well as the tension between parliamentary and popular sovereignty emerged, notably challenging the Fixed-term Parliaments Act 2011.

Weak answers were more limited in stating that Brexit may have affected the British constitution, but it's hard to measure the impact. Some answers argued the British constitution has managed to adapt to the changes, with the government and parliament eventually resolving their disagreements, showcasing the constitution's resilience, but did not provide much evidence for this.

2. 'Legislative outcomes in the UK are more to do with relationships within the legislature than the relationship between the legislature and the executive.' Do you agree?

8 Answers

Strong answers referenced the nuanced interplay between legislative dynamics and executive-legislative relationships significantly influences legislative outcomes in the UK. The Brexit negotiations, despite a Conservative majority, revealed intraparty discord that hindered legislative progression, shedding light on the concept of 'elective dictatorship', wherein a majority government can shape legislative agendas.

Weak answers were limited by looking only at how legislative outcomes in the UK hinge mainly on relationships within the legislature, while the relationship between the legislature and the executive seems less significant as they operate symbiotically, ensuring a smooth legislative process.

3. Why has the civil service been seen as more effective at policy design than policy implementation? Is this criticism fair?

11 Answers

Strong answers analysed the UK civil service's efficacy in policy design over implementation is attributed to its analytical and advisory prowess, yet its detachment from political realities and frontline service delivery might hinder effective policy execution. The criticism, while bearing merit, necessitates a broader discourse on civil service reform balancing bureaucratic expertise with implementation capacity.

Weaker answers focused only on the fact that the civil service is better at policy design as they can analyse things well, but they are not as good at implementing policies due to lack of experience or understanding of practical issues, making the criticism fair to an extent.

4. To what extent has the authority of British Prime Ministers been eroded by rising divisions in governing parties since 2010?

12 Answers

Strong answers looked at how  the authority of British Prime Ministers has been perceptibly eroded by intraparty divisions since 2010, as exemplified by the Conservative Party's internal strife over Brexit which challenged the leadership of David Cameron and Theresa May, as well as more recent cases. This trend underscores the evolving dynamics within governing parties, potentially reshaping the authoritative paradigm of Prime Ministerial governance.

Weaker answers also focused on how the authority of British Prime Ministers may have been affected by party divisions but were not specific about how and asserted that it's difficult to measure the extent. Leaders faced some challenges but they also found ways to manage their parties, showing a level of resilience in their authority.

5. Has the UK Supreme Court created a distinctive judicial politics?

10 Answers

Strong answers argued that the UK Supreme Court has indeed engendered a distinctive judicial politics, especially with landmark rulings like Miller I and II that delineated constitutional boundaries, embodying a nuanced shift towards a more assertive judicial review while navigating the delicate balance of parliamentary sovereignty.

Weak answers also stated the UK Supreme Court might have created a different judicial politics but limited their analysis to the idea that some cases have been controversial, which shows change in how politics and judiciary interact, but these answers did not detail whether the jurisprudence itself was new in historical perspective.

6. What did the Leveson Inquiry achieve in terms of reforming the culture, practices and ethics of the British press, relative to its aims?

7 Answers

Strong answers noted that the Leveson Inquiry marked a seminal juncture in striving to reform the British press culture, albeit with mixed success relative to its ambitious objectives. It engendered tangible reforms like the establishment of IPSO, yet fell short of instigating a comprehensive culture shift within the press, reflecting the intricate nexus between regulatory intent and entrenched media practices.

Weak answers were more limited in stating the inquiry aimed to change the press culture and had some success like creating IPSO, but it didn't achieve all its goals. That

the press still has issues was taken to show in of itself that the Inquiry might not have had a significant impact.

7. ‘Devolution has made UK governance more complicated, but otherwise done little to alter power relationships between the constituent nations.’ Do you agree?

13 Answers

Strong answers analysed how Devolution has ostensibly complexified UK governance without markedly altering power relations among the constituent nations. It introduced additional layers of governance, yet the asymmetrical devolution and persisting Westminster dominance reflect a continuance of centralised power dynamics, underscoring the nuanced intergovernmental relations in the UK's quasi-federal structure.

Weak answers leaned too heavily on the fact that the UK still has a centralised system with England dominating, showing that devolution didn't do much other than adding more layers to governance. There was some lack of awareness and analysis of what evolved legislatures have actually achieved.

8. Has cheap, accessible social media democratised political campaigning in the UK?

No answers

9. What measures need to be taken to ensure that all citizens are able to exercise their right to vote in UK elections freely and fairly?

2 Answers – too few to comment

10. What are the key differences between the major political parties’ strategies since 2010 and how have these influenced the results of elections?

8 Answers

Strong answers looked at the diverging political strategies of major UK parties since 2010 have significantly influenced electoral outcomes. The Conservative Party’s shift towards Euroscepticism contrasted with Labour’s internal ideological struggles, reflecting broader societal polarizations that resonated within the electorate, thus impacting election results and party fortunes.

Weaker answers argued that since 2010 the major political parties have had different strategies but did not develop a strong case for how and why these strategies were adopted. Answers also identified on how the Conservatives focused more on Brexit while Labour had internal issues, but did not show how their strategies concretely influenced the electoral outcomes.

11. Has the question of the UK’s relationship with the European Union now been largely resolved?

1 Answer – too few to comment

12. What do UK governmental responses to EITHER climate change OR the COVID pandemic show about state capacity in the UK?

1 Answer – too few to comment

# Report on A12722W1 Government and Politics in the United States

| Question | No. of answers |
|---|---|
| **1** | 10 |
| **2** | 3 |
| **3** | 2 |
| **4** | 6 |
| **5** | 5 |
| **6** | 6 |
| **7** | 2 |
| **8** | 2 |
| **9** | 9 |
| **10** | 0 |
| **11** | 8 |
| **12** | 13 |

The spread of questions taken was fairly diverse; the most popular questions were 12 (on media), 1 (on exceptionalism) and 9 (on the Supreme Court). There was a wide spread of marks; most answers showed considerable knowledge of a wide literature, but some struggled to engage fully (or even at all) with the question asked.

Some notes on particular questions:

1 - This question attracted a disappointing number of weak answers, in particular those which did not even attempt to answer the "from what" part of the question (and from candidates who, for other questions, seemed happy to answer the question asked). Stronger answers were able to use their knowledge of the literature to explain what the US is supposed to be exceptional from, in ways which illuminated their understanding of exceptionalism.

4/5/6 – all these questions were generally well answered, showing at least a solid knowledge of the literature and some insight into the question and its motivations. Better answers showed considerable theoretical sophistication and effectively used recent American political history to illustrate their points.

9 – Again, generally solidly answered. The strongest essays showed how the constraints of public reaction might vary over time and issue areas.

11 – The best answers to this question considered its framing: has the federal government in fact been attempting to ameliorate racial inequality but prevented from doing so?

12 – again, this very popular question invited some answers which ignored part of it, describing changes in media without addressing their political consequences. Better answers had convincing arguments about what has changed; few considered any impact beyond voters' use of social media.

# Report on A12724W1 Politics of Russia and the Former Soviet Union

16 candidates took the exam in Trinity Term 2023: 11 PPE students and 5 HPol students. The standard was average for an undergrad script. Final marks ranged from 60 to 76, with an overall average of 65. Four candidates achieved a First Class mark.

Frequency of responses: low (up to 5), high (more than 5).

1. **'There is no value in studying post-Soviet elections because the results are all consequences of vote fraud.' Do you agree? (Low) = 5**

Several candidates answered this question. Strong answers included literature on elections and voting, especially within authoritarian contexts. The showed a good understanding of the challenges to voting in post-Soviet states, including but not limited to vote fraud. Stronger scripts also showed heterogeneity between the post-Soviet states rather than homogenising the experience in all 15 former republics.

2. **In what ways has the rigidity of presidentialism influenced post-Soviet political outcomes? (Low) = 3**

Few candidates answered this question. The answers to this question were generally weak in comparison to the answers to other questions. Some discussed Linz's work on presidentialism, outlining the problems of term length, lack of accountability, and challenges to democracy. While demonstrating an understanding of the existing literature, few explicitly applied it to the post-Soviet states or showed a comparative understanding of presidents in the region.

3. **Is politics in the post-Soviet space dominated by strong political parties? (High) = 6**

This question produced strong answers. The strongest comparatively analysed party systems across the post-Soviet space by including specific cases and examples of where political parties have/have not dominated the political space. They also thoroughly engaged with the key literature on dominant parties and authoritarianism. Several of the scripts additionally considered the variation across the post-Soviet space by considering instances where political regimes have not successfully dominated politics, such as in Georgia.

4. **'Mikhail Gorbachev's perestroika was a deliberate attempt to break from Leninism.' Discuss. (High) = 9**

This question was the most frequently answered. The stronger scripts engaged with the competing debates, including the ideological underpinnings of Lenin's and Gorbachev's motivations and the distinctive approaches of each leader. Weaker scripts did not consider the global political environment, especially the 'objective' problems facing the USSR, but focused mostly on Gorbachev's reforms themselves.

5. **Is corruption in post-Soviet societies the result of individual-level behaviours or macro-level structures? (Low ) = 3**

Few candidates answered this question. Stronger scripts differentiated between individual-level behaviours and macro-level structures, but often arguing that they are not mutually exclusive as the former are very influenced by the latter. These scripts also engaged with key literature on political capitalism to show that the failed realisation of the welfare state and market capitalism can prompt individual-level behaviours like corruption. The stronger answers also provided good comparative examples.

6. **Was the collapse of the Soviet Union inevitable? (Low) = 2**

Few candidates answered this question. The scripts included some of the existing theories around the collapse of the USSR, including Chernobyl, Perestroika, and Archie Brown's concept of 'the Gorbachev Factor.' Still, it is noteworthy that students who answered Question 4 did not also answer this question given the potential for overlap.

7. **Is the era of colour revolutions over? (High) = 6**

Several candidates answered this question. The answers did a good job explaining what the colour revolutions were, why and how they occurred, and their outcomes. Most responses engaged with existing theories on protest and mobilisation in the former Soviet space, as well as drew on comparative examples. Strong scripts considered the structural factors in their answer to determine whether (and why) the era of revolutions may or may not be 'over.'

8. **Was nationalist mobilisation a cause or a consequence of weakening Soviet power? (Low) = 5**

The scripts generally examined the different drivers of nationalist mobilisation during the Soviet period. Many answers compared nationalist mobilisations in different republics to highlight variation, especially between the Baltics and Central Asia. The stronger scripts examined the role of Gorbachev's policies, especially Perestroika, for creating the structural conditions for nationalist mobilisation, rather than arguing that it was a weakening of Soviet power.

9. **To what extent does a 'resource curse' exist in post-Soviet Eurasia? (High) = 7**

Approximately half of the candidates answered this question. Strong scripts defined 'resource curse' and outlined theories around resources and authoritarianism. The answers particularly considered the role of elites, institutional arrangements, rent distribution and firm ownership, and electoral cycles. The stronger answers provided good comparative examples, as well as argued the need to study the presence of

natural resources within each individual state in post-Soviet Eurasia rather than attempting to homogenise the experience across all former republics.

**10. Is the concept of corruption too heterogenous to be helpful in understanding former Soviet societies? (Low) = 0**

No candidates answered this question.

**11. Have scholars of post-Soviet politics focused too much on competitive authoritarianism and not enough on other types of regimes? (Low) = 1**

One candidate answered this question.

12. **Explain the legacies of Soviet nationalities policy in post-Soviet societies. (Low) = 1**

One candidate answered this question.

# Report on A12726W1 Politics of Latin America

This paper was taken by 14 PPE candidates and one HPol candidate. This year, we adopted in-person typed examinations. The change of delivery did not appear to have any adverse effect and many of the scripts proved to be of very high quality. The average mark for this exam year was 65.53. The highest mark was 75 and the lowest mark was 45. There were two clear first-class honours and the majority of scripts proved to be of a good second-class honour, grade one standard. As is the norm for this paper, nearly all the scripts demonstrated a very good understanding of the wider theoretical literature, and the stronger scripts matched this theoretical knowledge with solid empirical knowledge. The very best scripts could successfully critically engage with the theoretical models and could illustrate the theoretical dynamics with reference to the actual politics of the region. The weaker scripts struggled to engage with some of the more complicated theoretical ideas in the literature and these scripts also struggled to demonstrate empirical knowledge.

This year, we continued to see a slight retreat from the previous trend for a greater spread in the choice of questions among candidates and a return to a focus on specific questions. Once again, the question related to the international political economy of the region received scant attention; quite a few scripts addressed the questions on democratisation (Q. 9) and party systems (Q. 7).

# Report on A12727W1 Politics in South Asia

Twelve questions were set in this year's paper, with seven out of the twelve attempted by the five candidates who sat the examination. Three questions were answered by three candidates: Question 1, which asked whether colonial institutional legacies explain variation in the state-building strategies of post-colonial states in South Asia and required a comparative answer; Question 8, which asked candidates to examine the continuities and discontinuities in the social institution of caste, across the colonial divide; and Question 10, which asked whether the overt nuclearisation of India and Pakistan in 1998 led to more peaceful inter-state relations. These were also among the more widely answered question themes in the 2022 exam. The best answers to Question 1 pointed to factors beyond colonial institutional legacies, while also taking the later seriously, and framed the cross-country comparison analytically and systematically. Good answers to Question 8 were able to critically examine the relationship between colonialism and caste and also trace the development of caste as a category in contemporary Indian/South Asian politics. Strong answers to Question 10 were critical about the definition of 'peaceful', drawing distinctions between strategic and sub-nuclear stability while also noting the particularities of the South Asian context. The very best answers to all three questions displayed depth and nuance. Question 2, focusing on the consequences of the regionalisation of Indian politics, and Question 6, which asked candidates whether religious nationalism poses a threat to democracy in South Asia, were each answered by two candidates. Questions 3 and 11, focussing on women's movements in South Asia and SAARC/regionalism, respectively, were each answered by 1 candidate. Five questions, Questions 4, 5, 7, and 9, 12 focussing on the salience of caste-based political mobilisation in India, the relationship between gender and Hindu nationalism, environmental movements, borders, and economic liberalisation, respectively, were not attempted. These were also, however, not questions that were popular among students during the Hilary Term revision classes. The spread of marks awarded (for the examination as a whole) was reasonably narrow, ranging from 65% (mid 2.1) to 75% (a mid 1st), with three candidates scoring above 70%. Overall, the answers demonstrated wide engagement with the literature and strong empirical knowledge. Weaker answers offered less comprehensive or less clearly-structured arguments, while stronger answers developed a systematic framework for the analysis and were targeted, systematic, empirically rich, critically-engaged and demonstrated broad coverage of the literature.

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# Report on A12730W1 International Relations in the Era of the Cold War

Total number of exam scripts: 23

General remarks: Essays were generally competent, but there were few essays that showed analytical sophistication or depth. Most essays presented historical material in a broadly accurate manner, but argumentation tended to be thin. Answers also tended to cluster around particularly broad questions focused on great power relations, even though the exam questions included more regionally focused questions or potentially more complex ones.

**Q1: 16 (23.5%)**

Most popular question. Students generally presented fair understanding of the relevant material. Strong distinction-level essays were able to think critically about the relationship between individual agency and broader structural causes.

**Q2: 4 (5.9%)**

Only few attempts, with some strong essays in the high 2:1 range able to demonstrate detailed knowledge of the Cuban Missile Crisis.

**Q3: 3 (4.4%)**

Only a few attempts, but essays were generally strong. Particularly strong essays showed good understanding of the evolution of China's role in the Cold War.

**Q4: 10 (14.7%)**

Essays ran the gamut in terms of quality, from the high 50s to 70s. Good essays were generally able to critically engage with the concept of 'success' and present nuanced argument based on what type of success the essay focused on.

**Q5: 10 (14.7%)**

Fairly strong essays across the board for this question. Stronger essays were able to draw upon more specific historical examples for evidence.

**Q6: 1 (1.5%)**

Only one attempt, lacking in historical detail and connection to the question.

**Q7: 0**

No attempts.

**Q8: 3 (4.4%)**

Only a few attempts with one particularly strong essay. The stronger essay had a firm grasp on the key historical events during the period and used them effectively to demonstrate the central argument.

**Q9: 12 (17.6%)**

Second most popular essay question with the majority of answers clustered around the mid-60s. Essays broadly discussed relevant historical material, but had not very sophisticated engagement with the theoretical element of the question (inevitability).

**Q10: 4 (5.9%)**

Answers ran the gamut between high 50s to 70s. The weaker essays simply laid out the variance without giving a causal argument to explain why the variance occurred.

**Q11: 1 (1.5%)**

Only one attempt, with a weak answer. The main issue was with the inaccurate understanding of relevant theoretical arguments.

**Q12: 1 (1.5%)**

Only one attempt with a weak answer. Main issue was with superficial understanding of containment policies and their effects.

# Report on A12731W1 International Relations

This year, 157 candidates sat the International Relations exam, of which 117 were PPE students and 40 were HP students. The overall mean mark was 65.49; the highest mark was 76, and the lowest mark was 37. All three figures are normal and similar to those in previous years.

The first quartile was 63 and the median 66, implying a decent command of the material by the vast majority of candidates. The proportion of marks over 70 was 21%, which seems reasonable – and is reassuring following last year's sharp rise. Less than 15% of marks were below 60, which is quite low. I would reiterate last year's suggestion that markers apply a slightly more stringent standard, while noting that several other papers have even lower proportions of marks in the 40s and 50s. Perhaps this issue merits a broader discussion among examiners.

Examiners cooperated efficiently to reconcile marks. As usual, a small number of scripts were sent to a third examiner when a mark could not be agreed.

Turning to the questions, a few familiar issues arose. There was some obvious overlap with other papers, in particular 297 International Security and Conflict. Moreover, many essays had a "rehearsed" character, trotting out familiar points and arguments while failing to directly engage with the rubric. For example, responses to Q4 (on structural power) tended to offer general discussions of the merits of various conceptions of power without addressing the key issue of "elusiveness." Finally, a handful of questions received the lion's share of responses, including Q8 on the democratic peace and Q12 on the Arab Spring. Few candidates attempted Q1 on classical approaches, Q11 on nationalism, or Q2 on international law.

Overall, however, this was an encouraging set of scripts.

# Report on A12732W1 Political Thought: Plato to Rousseau

17 candidates (14 PPE; 3 HPol)

**Overall assessment**

The overall quality of papers was high, with some splendid first-class performances. The strongest candidates unpacked the problems that lay behind the question and supported their interpretations with precise textual evidence. They deployed context to good effect, putting forward creative and careful readings which showed a real understanding of the questions at stake in the set texts. On the weaker end, some students failed to engage directly with the question or displayed only a superficial knowledge of the texts. But this was rare.

As usual, answers clustered around Plato, Machiavelli and Hobbes (10, 10 and 9 takers respectively). But the overall spread was encouraging, with all questions bar three receiving three or more answers. Only two questions (Hume and the thematic question on geographical comparisons) went unanswered.

**Individual Questions**

**1. 'There are three primary types of people: philosophic, victory-loving and profitloving.'**

**(PLATO) Can Plato's ideal city satisfy them all?**

10 answers, spanning the full range of marks. The best explored potential tensions between the Plato's three classes and offered their own assessment of whether or not these could be reconciled, drawing on specific textual detail. Some chose to focus on one specific class which Plato's city might fail to satisfy, usually the philosophic or the appetitive. A detailed case-study of either group could make for an effective answer. The weakest answers were dismissive of Plato's arguments, making no effort to explain his aims or considerations. In the middle of the range, answers that took a more analytical approach were rewarded, while those that fell into mere description were marked down.

**2. 'Women', 'slaves', 'barbarians' and 'animals'. Outline the role of at least TWO of**

**these groups in Aristotle's theory of politics.**

3 answers. The most thoughtful responses drew on feminist critiques of Aristotle to particularly good effect. It was a shame not to see more candidates addressing take up the cases of slaves and animals.

**3. What value does Aquinas attribute to the political community?**

Only two answers, but of a high quality, setting Aquinas in the context of the Aristotelian revival and medieval political debate.

**4. 'If you wonder, that I join a work of fancy to my serious philosophical contemplations; think not that it is out of a disparagement to philosophy.' (MARGARET CAVENDISH) Do**

**the imaginative elements of utopias limit their value as 'serious' political theory? Refer to at least ONE utopian text.**

4 answers. One of the best-answered questions on the paper. There were several stellar responses, which explored both pre-modern utopian writing and the role of utopianism in political theory more broadly. Most took Thomas More as their central focus, but drew effective comparisons to other writers too. It was very pleasing to see one candidate directly address Cavendish's concept of 'fancy'.

**5. Does Machiavelli think that the lessons of history differ for republics and princes?**

10 answers. Several candidates rose to the challenge of this question admirably, displaying an impressive grasp of relevant textual detail, as well as a sense of the role of history in Machiavelli's arguments as a whole. Many, however, struggled to provide specific evidence for Machiavelli's engagement with history, instead bringing out the usual greatest hits with little regard to the question. Several argued for continuity between *The Prince* and *The Discourses* without any reference to the lessons of history. In a popular question like this, precision and specificity are crucial to stand out from the crowd.

**6. 'But it is an easy thing, for men to be deceived, by the specious name of Libertie.' (THOMAS HOBBES) In what ways does Hobbes seek to undeceive his readers?**

9 answers. This was a popular question, but (with a few notable exceptions) surprisingly poorly answered. A lack of precision in defining the concept of liberty – as used by Hobbes or others – held a lot of candidates back. The best answers made clear what was at stake in the varying definitions of the term. A surprising number of candidates showed no awareness of ideas of republican liberty or Hobbes's objection to it.

**7. 'Locke was as conservative as a revolutionary could be.' Do you agree?**

3 answers. Fewer responses than usual to this question, but it proved a good differentiator, prompting answers of both the highest and lowest quality. Candidates' level of success depended on how effectively they defined what might be meant by the terms 'conservative' or 'revolutionary' in relation to Locke. These are indeed vague terms, and there were multiple directions in which candidates could have taken them. But these definitional difficulties needed to be recognised and tackled head on. Where they were, answers were be exciting, sophisticated and original.

**8. What, if anything, does Montesquieu think the French can learn from the English?**

3 answers. It was good to see three responses on Montesquieu – a rise on previous years. Even more encouragingly (and like the Utopia topic), these were answers of a universally high quality, offering meticulous analysis of which English ideas Montesquieu considered applicable in France, and which he did not.

**9. What are Hume's most significant criticisms of the British political and economic system?**

No answers.

**10. 'Where right and freedom are everything, inconveniences are nothing.' (JEANJACQUES ROUSSEAU) What, for Rousseau, are the inconveniences of freedom and why are they worth the effort?**

4 answers. A mixed bag of responses, with the highest proportion of 2.ii marks on the paper (redeemed by one 1st class mark). In the weaker answers, there was also a repeated failure to address what Rousseau meant by either freedom or its inconveniences. Even the better responses could have been clearer about the obligations of citizens in Rousseau's republic.

**11. Compare how at least TWO of the set authors use geographical comparisons to explain the workings of political life.**

No answers.

**12. What is the relationship between property and civic virtue? Answer with reference to at least TWO of the set authors.**

3 answers. Answers to this question were generally of a high, but not outstanding, quality. There was a general tendency to assume that property and civic virtue were naturally antithetical, with little recognition that property ownership has often been view as an essential precondition to civic virtue (reading more J.G.A. Pocock would help). As is often the case with thematic questions, answers also fell victim to the temptation to try and do too much. It was encouraging to see candidates addressing a diverse range of thinkers and making ambitious efforts to trace change over time, but candidates need to make their overarching arguments clearer and more precise to reach the highest level.

# Report on A12733W1 Political Thought: Bentham to Weber

This year Bentham to Weber attracted a strong pool of candidates who performed very well on the exam. Several candidates received first-class marks on at least one question. At least two scripts demonstrated a degree of engagement with the texts and the historical context that was close to graduate level. Overall, the papers showed that the history of political thought papers continue to attract and engage curious, dedicated and independently-minded students.

The advice we offer each year holds again for this one: most successful answers advance a high level of primary, secondary and contextual knowledge while offering clear and cogent arguments in response to the question. Students who went beyond the officially stipulated set texts tended to do particularly well – though not because this is a necessary condition for a high mark. Those students who had a view about why a text was written by an author, and were able to communicate that to the examiners, also tended to do well.

We will repeat this year a piece of advice we give every year: students who answer comparative questions are reminded that the skill here is to work out how to bring textual nuance to an answer that, by necessity, allows you less space to focus extensively on a single thinker's views. Too often comparative answers remain superficial or abstracted from the particularities of an author's claims.

Finally, another reminder that we often repeat, despite stating it here every year: students who wish to take a more squarely philosophical approach to the question should remember that they ought still to use the text – or at least refer to the text – to make their arguments.

# Report on A12734W1 Marx and Marxism

Paper sat by 19 candidates.

**1. Is it accurate to claim that, whilst Marx might occasionally play with Hegelian modes of expression, his substantive intellectual debts to Hegel are few and unimportant?**

Answered by 0 candidates.

Too few answers to comment.

**2. Does the critique of 'utopian socialism' that the writings of Marx and Engels contain indicate that they are 'at once anti-utopian and utopian'?**

Answered by 9 candidates.

This was a popular question, and there were some good answers. However, some candidates struggled to say much about the possibility of 'utopian' threads in the writings of Marx and Engels, and perhaps put too much weight on their own denial that they were utopians. (Fourier, Owen, and Saint-Simon, also denied that they were utopians.) Not all candidates had much first-hand knowledge of the ideas of the utopian socialists themselves, and some appeared content to trust Marx and Engels' own accounts of their opponents' views.

**3. 'Marx's accounts of alienation and ideology both play very similar roles in his thought, explaining why the proletariat might not always rebel.' Discuss.**

Answered by 6 candidates.

Candidates often had a good understanding of alienation, but accounts of ideology were more varied in quality (and often lacked much in the way of textual evidence for the attribution of those accounts to Marx). Not all candidates took advantage of the distinction between 'objective alienation' and 'subjective alienation' in order to address the alienation part of the question. Not all candidates engaged very critically with the assumption (in the quotation) that Marx sought to explain the failure of the proletariat to rebel.

**4. Do Marx's various accounts of the state in capitalist society all fail to recognise the modern state's independence of the economically dominant class?**

Answered by 7 candidates.

A popular question. Some candidates were *over*-reliant in Jon Elster's typology of three models of the state in capitalist society found in Marx's writings. Elster's typology is undoubtedly helpful, but it is not the only possible interpretation, and it cannot substitute for familiarity with Marx's own primary texts. Many candidates struggled to

talk clearly and precisely about the possibility that the state's 'independence', in this context, might be a scalar concept (might admit of degrees).

**5. Does Marx's theory of history depend upon his conception of human nature?**

Answered by 5 candidates.

Candidates typically had a good understanding of Marx's theory of history, but some struggled a little with the precise question asked. Answers were also strikingly diverse; from those portraying historical materialism as independent of particular human nature claims, and others portraying it as dependent on them. As ever, better answers weighed the evidence, and did not simply dismiss alternative interpretations without explanation.

**6. 'Despite his own protestations, Marx does have a clear moral vision, and "the Needs Principle" is at the heart of it.' Discuss.**

Answered by 8 candidates.

Candidates typically had a good general understanding of the broader topic here – Marx and morality – but not all were adept in treating this particular question. The precise character of the needs principle was not always well outlined and explored. It might be that future candidates should reflect on whether, and in what ways, the needs principle might help make sense of the normative and moral dimensions of Marx's thought.

**7. Since work in capitalist society is not always poorly paid, unhealthy, and insecure, is Marx mistaken in thinking that such work necessarily involves exploitation?**

Answered by 7 candidates.

Not all candidates were familiar with the (extensive) secondary literature on Marx's account of exploitation. However, there were some good answers, and many candidates recognised that Marx's account of exploitation seems to allow that work that was well-paid, healthy, and secure, could still involve 'exploitation'. The relation between the account of exploitation and the labour theory of value still seems to confuse some, and it might be worth reminding students that Marx does not limit exploitation to capitalist society; for example, he identifies exploitation in feudal society (in which the labour theory of value is not operative).

**8. 'Bernstein's critique of Marx's philosophical account of historical inevitability is more persuasive than his empirical disagreements with Marx's predictions about the economic tendencies of capitalism.' Discuss.**

Answered by 6 candidates.

Candidates do not always show good first hand familiarity with Bernstein's writings, and some answers could look over-reliant on their lecture notes, or other secondary sources. In general, candidates were better at addressing the 'empirical

disagreements' part of the question, than the philosophical disagreements with 'historical inevitability' part of the question.

**9. Are Marxist accounts of the political form of future communist society rightly characterised as 'republican'? Discuss with reference, EITHER to Marx, OR to later Marxists.**

Answered by 1 candidate.

Too few answers to comment.

**10. Did any contemporary Marxist critics offer a clear and persuasive alternative to Lenin's account of the relationship between party and class? Answer with reference to ONE OR MORE of the following authors: Luxemburg and Trotsky.**

Answered by 3 candidates.

This is a small sample, making generalisations difficult. However, it can be said that this question did not always reveal extensive first-hand textual knowledge of the relevant Marxist authors. Contrasts between Lenin and Luxemburg, in particular, were sometimes a little stark and overly simplistic.

**11. 'Early Marxist critiques of the Bolshevik Revolution were mistaken in assuming that only two stable outcomes were possible (that the new Russian regime must either fall back into capitalism, or move forward into socialism).' Discuss with reference to ONE OR MORE of the following authors: Luxemburg, Kollantai, Kautsky, and Trotsky.**

Answered by 2 candidates.

Too few answers to comment.

**12. 'Gramsci's writings cannot be understood without knowledge of the political situation in interwar Italy, the context with which they are always concerned.' Discuss.**

Answered by 3 candidates.

There were some very different responses to this question, amongst this small sample, making generalisations difficult. However, whether or not a candidate wants to agree with or challenge the quotation in the question, they should think seriously about why one might accept it (which is hard to do that without knowing something about the Italian context in which Gramsci worked). Candidates did not always show good first-hand familiarity with Gramsci's writings.

# Report on A12735W1 Sociological Theory

There were 9 students that completed the examination. The overall quality of the scripts was surprisingly consistent. While the cohort is small, the standard across it was good but not outstanding. Reflecting this only one student achieved a mark of over 70, while none of the students achieved a mark of below 60. Given the small size of the sample, it is not unexpected that particularly weak performances might be absent (or that there might not be additional high scoring scripts). There was fairly good coverage across the questions that were answered, with only three out of the twelve questions not receiving a response. Questions 5, 8 and 9 received the most responses. While it is hard to discern why some questions were favoured over others, these three questions address some of the most central sociological topics of all: Social Networks, Norms and Collective Action.

# Report on A12737W1 Political Sociology

Overall, the standard of answers was very good as usual.

Using the opening sentence to provide a succinct headline answer to the question was an effective style for many candidates, especially if the main points supporting that answer were summarised in the rest of the opening paragraph.

The best candidates discussed the strengths and limitations of the evidence base they were using, rather than simply the research findings from the papers cited.

One-line spaces between paragraphs help readability, which is appreciated by assessors.

None of the assessors marking the paper reported any systematic issues with answers to particular questions.

# Report on A12740W1 Social Policy

This paper was taken by 24 students. All questions were answered by at least one student except for question 9 (pensions). There was a high concentration of answers on a few questions. The most popular questions were those focusing on poverty (Q7), social policy analysis (Q4) and the mixed economy of welfare (Q1). Less than three students addressed the questions on welfare regimes (Q2), disability or housing (Q6) and the post-war welfare consensus (Q8). The average mark was 66 (lowest 55, highest 75).

| **Q** | **1** | **2** | **3** | **4** | **5** | **6** | **7** | **8** | **9** | **10** | **11** | **12** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A | 15 | 2 | 6 | 10 | 6 | 2 | 11 | 1 | 0 | 5 | 7 | 7 |

**Q1 (mixed economy of welfare),**

This was the most popular question (21% of answers). The best answers provided a nuanced interpretation of shifts in the UK welfare mix under different governments and considered and critically evaluated different actors (market, third sector, families) as well as functions (provision, funding, regulation). The weakest answers showed understanding of core material but were more limited in breadth, lacked a clear definition of core concepts such as efficiency and equity, remained descriptive or failed to build a coherent argument, and/or contained significant mistakes.

**Q3 (immigration)**

The strongest answers developed complex arguments drawing on a wide array of authors and theories. They clearly explained how immigration rights determine access to social rights through eligibility rules and linked those arguments to citizenship and concrete examples of policy developments from the UK and elsewhere. The weakest answers showed understanding of the question but made use of more limited or less relevant material, lacked a well-developed argument, and contained occasional mistakes.

**Q4 (social policy analysis)**

This was among of the most popular questions (14% of answers). The best answers developed analytical arguments drawing on theories of agenda setting and pluralism and might have included reference to evidence-based policymaking. The weakest answers only partly addressed the question, relied on more limited material, included some irrelevant concepts or sources, and were marred by common-sense arguments rather than informed by theories of the policy process.

**Q5 (family policies)**

The best answers provided a careful analysis of family policy development, included different types of drivers (e.g. female employment, child poverty, party ideology, etc.) and linked them to specific policy measures. The poorest answers were not as comprehensive in terms of either drivers or policies, contained inaccuracies and made limited use of policy examples, e.g. they might have mentioned relevant political and socio-demographic transformations driving change but failed to connect them to concrete examples of policy measures.

**Q7 (poverty)**

This was one of the more popular questions (15% of answers). The best answers demonstrated an excellent command of material, included analytical discussions of the definition of poverty, related means-testing to efficiency, stigma and poverty traps and used illustrations from UK policies. They may have contained occasional mistakes. The poorest answers lacked a full grasp of the topic, might have contained irrelevant references and/or mistakes and inaccuracies, made limited use of policy literature and lacked breadth.

**Q 10 (labour market)**

The best answers developed analytical arguments which demonstrated knowledge of the evolution of activation policies and paid attention to both moral and economic arguments. The poorest answers demonstrated knowledge of core material but lacked breadth and/or only addressed one aspect of the question (either moral or economic reasons).

**Q11(health)**

The best answers demonstrated command of the literature on the social determinants of health and knowledge of key pieces of legislation and theories. The weakest answers addressed the question only in part, referred to less relevant aspects or theories, failed to build a coherent argument, did not demonstrate understanding of the social gradient of health/health gap, and remained descriptive.

*Q12 (education)*

The best answers clearly defined educational disadvantage, and demonstrated an in-depth understanding of education policies in the UK also referring to key pieces of legislations (e.g. quasi markets, academies, sure start). The weakest answers demonstrated knowledge of core policies but lacked a secure grasp of the topic, were too narrowly focused on a few policy measures and/or remained descriptive.

*This report does not include the analysis of the scripts of seven human sciences students.*

# Report on A12741W1 Comparative Demographic Systems

This paper was taken by 3 candidates in 2023. In the past three years, we had around six students, so, halving their number, performance on the quantitative demography part of the paper (Part A) was consistently strong.

Students demonstrated a solid understanding of projection concepts to describe population change patterns and were able to interpret and contextualise the measures they had calculated well.

For Part B of the paper, essay questions linked to topics in epidemiological transition, life expectancy, and Malthus were very popular. Two of the three students focused on the life expectancy question. All three students produced excellent essays, with one student receiving a first class. The essays demonstrated a good understanding of the broader context of the factors and theoretical perspectives explaining the population change and differences across contexts of analysis. The strongest essays across all topics were those that integrated both theoretical explanations with empirical examples, as well as discussions of measurement issues and research design.

FR

# Report on A12743W1 Politics in China

Although it was a fairly large group of finalists, fewer than 20% attained first class marks, which is unusual for the paper. There was also a higher proportion of 2.iis than in the past. There was also considerable unevenness in the take-up of particular questions, with an unusually large number choosing to respond to Question 9. Other popular questions included 2, 4, 5, and 6. Candidates generally performed quite well on Question 2, perhaps in part because the question directly engaged two or three readings that were featured in one week's lecture; and because there was some conceptual and empirical overlap with Question 4, both were popular choices. Question 9—on popular contention—was far and away the most popular choice. The most successful answers discussed both the rational calculus of central and local governments in responding to protest (the choice between repression and concession), but also the range of newer ex ante measures, including bargained authoritarian measures and relational repression.

Fewer than 5 answered 1, 3, 5, 7, 8, 11 and 12.

Question breakdown

| Questions | No. of answers |
|---|---|
| 1 | 2 |
| 2 | 7 |
| 3 | 4 |
| 4 | 9 |
| 5 | 9 |
| 6 | 8 |
| 7 | 2 |
| 8 | 4 |
| 9 | 13 |
| 10 | 5 |
| 11 | 2 |
| 12 | 1 |

# Report on A12744W1 Politics of the EU

Eight (seven PPE students and one MHP) students sat this paper in June 2023. The students did well, two exams reached an overall mark above 70 (highest mark 73), five exams were above 60 (upper second) and one exam - lower second (54). The mean was 64.75. This result is slightly lower compared to previous years.

The distribution of answers was as follows:

| Question | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 | 11 | 12 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| number of answers | 1 | 5 | 4 | 2 | | 1 | 2 | 1 | 2 | 2 | 3 | 1 |

Students had to answer 3 out of 12 essay questions, and the distribution of chosen questions ensured that students had to draw on diverse set of topics that had been covered throughout the course. The topics included Common Foreign and Security Policy, the EU in crisis, theories of European integration, European Union institutions and institutional reforms. The strong engagement with a diverse set of topics shows that students have developed a broad range of interests. In addition to discussing recent political challenges such as EU foreign and security policy and the impact of the recent crisis, students have also reflected on theoretical debates and evaluated the explanatory power of different theoretical approaches.

Exams above 60 were able to present their argument in a coherent and correct fashion but were more limited in scope and lacked wider political considerations and critical reflection. Exams above 65 had to showcase the ability of independent analysis, even with missing aspects or few shortcomings. The two exams marked 73 needed to go beyond what had been covered in the lectures, go beyond textbook chapters and had to display a critical engagement with the wider academic scholarship. They showcased excellent factual knowledge about a wider variety of different aspects, a sound line of analytical argumentation, with convincing critical reflection.

# Report on A15594W1 Special Subject International Security and Conflict

AR

We had 48 finalists. Average marks for overall questions was 67, with a range of 60-72.

These were the 12 questions that were posed:

1. What is the next big challenge for international security?
2. What theory does provide the best explanation for the 2022 Russian War against Ukraine?
3. Can constructivism explain the emergence and evolution of the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation?
4. Does rebel leadership matter for civil wars' outbreaks?
5. Is the nuclear peace a result of deterrence, norms, or institutions?
6. Why terrorism is so present in countries experiencing other violent conflicts?
7. Under what conditions political identities matter for mass atrocities?
8. Is forced displacement of people only an outcome of conflict?
9. Is sexual violence in civil wars a tool of warfare?
10. Are non-violent collective campaigns more successful than violent ones? Why?
11. Is cyberspace a force of order or disorder in the international system?
12. First, describe the features of a successful UN peace operation. Second, do all operations look like the one you described? Why?

In the following table : frequency of questions tackled, average mark with lowest and highest marks and standard devotion.

| Question | Number Answers | Average Mark | mingrade | maxgrade | s.d. grade |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Q2 | 23 | 68 | 58 | 78 | 4.5 |
| Q7 | 21 | 68 | 62 | 78 | 4.0 |
| Q4 | 18 | 67 | 62 | 78 | 4.9 |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Q9 | 18 | 68 | 62 | 78 | 4.0 |
| Q5 | 16 | 66 | 62 | 73 | 2.9 |
| Q6 | 15 | 66 | 62 | 73 | 3.6 |
| Q12 | 10 | 69 | 62 | 85 | 7.2 |
| Q1 | 8 | 67 | 62 | 78 | 5.5 |
| Q11 | 8 | 67 | 62 | 73 | 3.9 |
| Q8 | 5 | 70 | 58 | 78 | 8.3 |
| Q10 | 1 | 73 | 73 | 73 | |
| Q3 | 1 | 73 | 73 | 73 | |

Overall, the best answers ( high 2.1/ first) went beyond the required readings ( that in the ISC syllabus are clearly identified) using also further readings and the most recent readings published in top security journals such as International Security, Security Studies, International Organizations, Journal of Peace Research and the Journal of Conflict Resolution.

Moreover, top performers, first, answered the questions clearly since the introduction, defined sharply the core concepts making references to specific works ( also highlighting possible tensions between definitions) and assessing systematically competing arguments using short case studies ( not mere anecdotes dropping).

The most answered question was Q2 ( War/Ukraine and Russia), the best answers provided an evaluation of different theories ranging from rationalist explanation, overconfidence, power transition and prospect theory.

The second most answered question was Q7 (political identities /mass atrocities), the best answers assessed the salience of political identities against the role of leadership and role of war.

Then Q4 followed in popularity, there the best answers compared the role of leadership with structural features, role of economic incentives and role of ideology. Same

popularity Q9,  where a proper answer gave context about the possible mechanisms of sexual violence ( introducing first and second order mechanims ) and then sowing how empirically we mostly see a core role of second order mechanism.

Overall an answer to avoid to be a 2.2– rather than imposing a pre-prepared argument – answer in a straightforward way the questions avoid to take tangential directions; define concepts; structure the essay ( using also subheadings to be sure that each paragraph conveys core points) making a selection of core points ( “less is  more “). Furthermore, a successful answer provides different perspectives based on different academic works rather then basing sections on just a single author. The use of empirics – qualitative and statistics - helps to reach high 2.1 , sharp and clear answers explaining WHY and HOW a conclusion is reached are essential elements for a first.

# Report on A15601W1 Advanced Paper in Theories of Justice

44 candidates sat this paper this year. Marks were rather concentrated in the 2.1 range: there was 1 mark lower than 40, 4 marks in the 50-59 range, 33 marks in the 60-69 marks, and 6 in the 70+ range. The median mark was 65. Candidates are generally demonstrating good knowledge of the literature, but there is a tendency to rely too heavily on tutorial essays and not address the specifics of the exam question, as will be noted from the comments below. It is significant that this happened in particular to the two most popular questions (2) and (4). As last year, answers were unsurprisingly concentrated on the questions that address specific syllabus topics rather than raising more general issues relating to theoretical work on justice and injustice. The (relatively) new topics of justice and healthcare and UBI now seem well integrated into the course, though the most popular questions related to migration, historical injustice, justice and children, and environmental justice.

**1. 'Trade is just insofar as it is to the advantage of all parties involved.' Discuss. (6 answers)**

A relatively straightforward question that picked up some knowledgeable and well-argued answers.

**2. Are states morally entitled to restrict migration in order to protect national culture? (26 answers)**

The most popular question. A significant number of candidates were too quick to write standard essays on migration and national self-determination here, and did not do enough to think about the protection of national culture specifically.

**3. Are questions of environmental justice helpfully distinguished from questions of distributive justice? (16 answers)**

A challenging question: less good answers rehearsed familiar debates on the allocation of the costs of climate change, better answers were able to put this material in the context of wider questions of distributive justice, some drawing, for example, on Simon Caney's distinction between integrationism and isolationism.

**4. Does benefiting from historic injustice give rise to contemporary reparative obligations? (25 answers)**

Another popular question, and again too many candidates launched straight into generic discussion of the BPP without thinking specifically about the "historic" injustice part of the question.

**5. 'Our duties of intergenerational justice are restricted to ensuring that the well-being of future generations is no worse than our own.' Discuss. (8 answers)**

Better answers were able to draw on a range of writings on, for example, the just savings principle or intergenerational discounting, some less strong answers struggled to discuss much more than the non-identity problem.

**6. Can social contract theory take sufficient account of the rights and interests of disabled people? (11 answers)**

Some well informed and well written answers here by candidates who resisted the temptation to focus on the distinction between the medical and social models.

**7. Is it sufficient for justice in healthcare that all have access to an adequate basic level of provision? (7 answers)**

A relatively small number of answers, but generally demonstrating good knowledge of relevant literature.

**8. Is it wrong for parents to seek to pass on their political views to their children? (18 answers)**

Again, some good knowledge, but better answers were able to say something distinctive about *political* views specifically.

**9. Should egalitarians support the provision of Universal Basic Income? (8 answers)**

Some answers struggled to focus on the egalitarian case for UBI specifically.

**10. Can it ever be morally appropriate to apologise for something that somebody else did? (3 answers)**

A challenging question, but some interesting and thoughtful answers.

**11. 'Contemporary theoretical work on justice and injustice still pays too much attention to questions of ideal theory.' Discuss. (0 answers)**

0 answers.

**12. 'Principles of justice should be constructed in relation to the specific practices they aim to regulate.' Discuss. (2 answers)**

Not a popular question but proved tempting to those familiar with the literature on practice dependence.

# Report on A17325W1 Comparative Political Economy

Report to follow.

# Report on A17606W1 Special Subject in Philosophy / Politics: Feminist Theory

The overall performance on the Special Subject in Feminist Theory was good, with most candidates receiving high 2:1 marks. The very best scripts combined deep textual engagement – quoting as appropriate from readings and drawing on texts not on the reading list – together with clear argumentative analysis. Some demonstrated a knowledge of historical context, which was both welcome and rewarded. Less successful scripts avoided the question set, showed a limited acquaintance with the readings (e.g. 'Some argue that…), and/or dumped large quantities of information and ideas without giving them adequate argumentative form.

Many candidates chose to answer Question 3, on whether feminism should only concern itself with those forms of oppression that women alone experience. Many candidates did not register the precise question asked: viz. whether feminism should only concern itself with the forms of oppression that *only* women face, as opposed to those forms of oppression that both women and some non-women (e.g. men) face. Instead, many candidates read the question as asking whether feminism should concern itself only with those forms of oppression that *all* women experience – and thus used the question as an occasion to download a generic answer about intersectionality. The very best essays understood the question being asked, and connected intersectional concerns with the plight of non-women – i.e. certain men and non-binary people.

Question 5, which asked candidates whether Pat Califa was right to claim that 'sexual preferences are more like flavor preferences than like moral/political alliances', also received several answers. Again, many candidates ignored the specificity of the question, using it as an occasion to elaborate on a host of issues to do with racialised sexual preferences, sexual orientation, the perils of moralism, etc. The best answers took the time to think about the contrast between flavour preferences and moral/political alliances, and applied that to the case of sexual preferences, properly defined.

Question 2, on pornography, was again a popular choice among candidates. But most answers simply took it as a generic invitation to write about feminist accounts of pornography, rather than as an invitation to address the specific challenge to the MacKinnonite/Langtonian view of pornography advanced by Webster. The very best answers addressed the challenge head-on.

A similar phenomenon occurred with regard to Question 14, on sex work, which again was among the most popular questions. Many candidates took it as an opportunity to download an essay on sex work, rather than address the specific line of argument advanced by Sonya Aragon. The best candidates noticed that Aragon's treatment of sex work seeks to reject both radical feminist arguments against sex work *and* the pro-decriminalisation, 'sex work is work' view advanced by e.g. Juno Mac and Molly Smith.